

The Gurus OF JOY

SRI SRI RAVI SHANKAR He has Art of Living Centres spread across 140 countries. His lyrical airfests have changed the lives of many. If this wasn't enough, more than 15 lakh people have pursued a course in sudarshan kriya, a healing breathing exercise.



BABA RAMDEV He is the reason the some Indians have been rubbing their fingernails in the hope of living without diabetes. Even remote villages in Sikkim host his "shivirs" now, all starting at the Patanjali Yog Peeth in Uttaranchal that continues to be his seat.



MATA AMRITANANDAMAYI DEVI She has already cuddled 20 million people into happiness from her ashram in Kerala. Add to this, the money she spends on philanthropy, including sending blankets to Kashmiris and Pakistanis in winter, and you can't ignore the do-gooder in her.



JAGGI VASUDEV Call me Jaggi, says the guru who's seen more often riding his Harley-Davidson and BMW bikes than praying at the altar. Tamil Nadu-based Vasudev's philosophy is truly new age—a combination of yoga, spiritual therapy and green activism has made him hip in the West with over a 100 centres all over the world.



middle-aged women who are trying to come to terms with a stage in their lives when their youth is over, and their children are leaving home.

Baba Ramdev, the sleek and apparently ageless television yogi and proponent of Ayurveda, implores people to practise pranayama and asana, and to take his particular brand of Ayurvedic treatments. His mass television audience of metro-matriarchs studiously follows his lithe routines on early morning spots that are shown daily on Aastha Channel, Sahara, India TV and Star News. If 5.30 a.m. is too early for them, they can turn to his wide selection of multi-media offerings, or go to one of his large-venue yoga camps. He claims that his methods will rid his audience of 'all ailments including obesity (overweight), spondylitis, high blood pressure, arthritis and chronic stomach ailment'. He claims also to have affidavits from those he has helped to cure cancer, and shrugged off a controversy when Indian papers said he claimed he could cure AIDS. He had been misquoted, he said, with a soft smile, and that he only claimed to alleviate the suffering of AIDS patients. And the comfortably-girthed and chronically diabetic drink it in, promising themselves that they will try and avoid Babaji's evil twins of fast food and fizzy drinks.

But is it yoga, and do these methods really bring people closer to a sense of the ultimate truth? What seems to be happening is a synthesis that recognises the intense pressures of the modern world, and the need to counter this in some way to create a human balance. In Gurgaon, the recently opened management leadership school, School of Inspired Leadership, SOIL, has made yoga asana and philosophy a major part of its curriculum for training advanced management students to be inspiring leaders. Around the country, yoga centres are opening all the time, teaching in both the

ABOUT 10 CRORE PEOPLE WATCH MY programmes. Speaking is not my passion. If I give ayurvedic treatment to people, what's the problem?

BABA RAMDEV,
YOGA GURU

SPIN-OFFS

Peace Mantra

Kapalbhati Clubs Pranayam lovers gather to do their 15 minutes of breathing exercises guaranteed to reduce weight.

Yoga Retail From non-skid mats to entire high-end stores like Urban Yoga that sell yoga lines, designer yoga is the order of the day.

Satwik Living A step further from organic, it is simplifying your life, not in terms of material possessions, but in terms of food habits. Call it new-age dieting.

Quick-fix Readers Elizabeth Gilbert's *Eat Pray and Love*, soon to be a movie starring Julia Roberts, and Robin Sharma's *The Monk Who Sold His Ferrari* have flown off the book shelves.

New-age Yoga Types Other than the six traditional forms of yoga—hatha, raja, karma, bhakti, jnana and tantra—Ashtanga yoga, an offshoot of the hatha form and Bharat Thakur's artistic yoga that combines age-old asanas with cardio stretches, are popular picks. Also, power yoga, a form of do-it-fast exercise, is believed to be responsible for Kareena Kapoor's ultra-slim figure.

more traditional way, and the often more physical Western version. It could be argued that the movement now generically dubbed as Spirituality Inc. is simply an evolution that shows the versatility of the path and the practice. It can also be argued that the changes reflect the spoilt laziness of a modern culture that wants all its ailments and worries resolved right here right now. But as one teacher I studied under many years ago put it, "It doesn't matter why you come to the practise, whether it's because you want a better-shaped bottom, or some peace of mind, it's going to get you in the end because it is simply bigger than you are."

Justine Hardy is an author and teacher of yoga philosophy in both India and the UK.

